

THE KNOCK.

1. INT. FAMILY HOUSE - PARENTS' BEDROOM - NIGHT

Rain hits the windows in steady bursts. The ceiling fan turns overhead, slow, uneven. Every few seconds: a tired CREAK — the sound stretched, strained, as if gravity itself groans.

BIRD'S-EYE VIEW — fixed at the ceiling's center. The entire room in a single frame.

The CAMERA ROTATES clockwise. Painfully slow. One continuous circle, as if the room is on a hinge.

The pace shifts subtly — drifting faster, then slower — as if words command gravity.

Soft fluorescent from the top-left washes the space. Flat, clinical falloff. No corner to hide in.

The room is neat. Too neat. An order that feels unnatural.

Right side: a pressed POLICE UNIFORM on a hanger. Above the desk: MEDALS and PHOTOGRAPHS — a small shrine.

On the desk: a laptop, lid open, screen black. Beside it, a half-empty glass of milk — untouched, forgotten. Childhood turned sour.

The bed takes the weight of the frame.

MOTHER on the left. FATHER on the right. Awake. Facing each other.

They speak softly, carefully — plea under a hard edge.

MOTHER
(low, contained)
You can't keep hitting him. Not for everything.

FATHER
(quiet, set)
He has to learn.

MOTHER
He's growing. He needs more than the belt.

FATHER
Discipline doesn't change with age.

She steadies herself. Her hand grips the sheet, then loosens.

MOTHER
Be his father. Be his friend. Make memories. Not scars.

The FAN CREAKS. The room holds its breath.

MOTHER
(softer, almost to him)
He loves you. More than anyone.
You're his hero.

The RAIN SOFTENS. The FAN'S SOUND drops away — blades still turning in silence.

The CAMERA ROTATION continues, heavy, relentless.

CUT TO:

CLOSE-UP — A CHILD'S DRAWING.

A cheap wooden frame lying flat on the desk. Crayon: a smiling policeman.

In the corner, a shaky hand: "MY DAD."

The frame reflects faint rain streaks in glass.

FATHER
He says that. Says I'm the one he
loves most—

MOTHER
He does. He means it.

FATHER
(cuts in, breaking)
No. It's you. Always you.

FATHER (V.O.)
I cut things early. Small mistakes
— you fix them before they root.
If you don't, they grow. I've seen
it. I won't let it touch him.

The CAMERA still rotates, gaining an almost imperceptible push of speed.

Sharp KNOCK at the door twice. The rotation JOLTS TO A STOP — like a record scratch. Silence, except faint rain.

On Screen Title: THE KNOCK.

Father rises and walks to the door.

CUT TO:

ANGLE — BEHIND FATHER AT THE DOOR

His knuckles blanch on the knob. He opens it a crack—

—The SIXTEEN-YEAR-OLD BOY'S FACE in the gap.

A slap welt burns his right cheek. Lip split on the edge.
Belt marks lace his neck and arm.

His eyes burn at his father, then flick over his shoulder –
to his mother.

CUT TO:

ANGLE – BEHIND THE BOY

He stands centered in the doorway. The room beyond
symmetrical, fragile – a family tableau held in place.

Father steps aside. The boy enters.

CUT TO:

CLOSE-UP – THE DRAWING.

The smiling policeman. The shaky "MY DAD."

We HOLD as the boy crosses the room – blurred reflection
rippling across glass.

CUT TO:

BIRD'S-EYE VIEW – STATIC.

The whole room again. No rotation now.

The boy climbs onto the bed between them.

He curls into his mother. She wraps an arm around him,
smoothing his hair.

He drapes a leg over her, eyes fixed on his father.

Father lies back beside him. He places his hand over the boy
– just above the mother's.

They hold. Breathing. Quiet.

The FAN CREAKS once – then stops dead, though shadows of its
blades still crawl across the ceiling.

The RAIN softens – as if listening.

CUT TO:

CLOSE ON THE MOTHER.

Her hand strokes the boy's hair. She studies his face,
searching. Then –

MOTHER
 (soft, almost playful, but
 breaking)
 Tell me something...
 Who do you love the most? Me, or
 Dad?

CUT TO:

CLOSE ON THE SON.

SON
 (Without hesitation)
 Dad.

SILENCE slams down.

The RAIN echoes — distorted now, faintly metallic, as though
 the word itself reverberates in the walls.

CUT TO:

CLOSE ON THE FATHER.

The words hit him. His throat works. He forces it out, quiet,
 aching—

FATHER
 Why me? Not your mom?

CUT TO:

CLOSE ON THE SON.

Eyes locked. Unwavering.

SON
 It's you, Dad.
 Always you.

His lip trembles — not fear. Certainty.

CUT TO:

MONTAGE:

CLOSE-UP — the MOTHER'S eyes, glassed but refusing to break.

CLOSE-UP — the FATHER, guilt and pride colliding in silence.

CLOSE-UP — the SON, pressed between them, body marked but his
 choice clear.

BACK TO:

BIRD'S-EYE VIEW — static, symmetrical.

A family locked in place, suspended.

CUT TO:

CLOSE-UP — THE DRAWING, ONE LAST TIME.

The crayon smile. The shaky "MY DAD."

The silence is deafening.

SMASH CUT TO:

2. INT. FAMILY HOUSE - HALLWAY - NIGHT

Silence.

The CAMERA MOVES SLOW, LEFT TO RIGHT, across a pale hallway wall.

Wallpaper — faded flowers, peeling, rotting at edges.

A FAMILY PORTRAIT — Father, Mother, Son. Studio-lit. Their smiles stiff, rehearsed.

SON (V.O.)
We never really value a moment...
until it becomes a memory.

The CAMERA TRACKS right.

A BLACK-RIBBONED PHOTO — the Father, alone, uniformed, formal.

SON (V.O.)
The next year, he was gone.
I buried my father, my best friend
when I'm 16 years old.

The CAMERA glides further.

A WEDDING PHOTO — the Mother in white. Her smile sharper, brittle.

Her hand on the arm of the Father's colleague — now her husband.

The man looks solid. Decent. Too decent.

SON (V.O.)
She remarried. His colleague. A
good man. Better, maybe.
(beat)
But blood doesn't get replaced.
Not in my head. Not in my heart.

The CAMERA DOLLIES IN slowly.

The smiles warp behind glass, distorted.

Reflections of rain streaks drag across their faces.

The SOUND of the ceiling fan creeps back — warped, slowed, like blades struggling through molasses.

The CAMERA DOLLIES IN further. The photo swells, swallowing frame.

The rain's reflection flickers like veins across the glass.

SMASH CUT TO:

3. INT. BOARDING SCHOOL - DAY/NIGHT UNKNOWN

MONTAGE — BRUTAL, DISORIENTING:

— A fist connects with his jaw. FLASH CUT.

— A shoe slams into his ribs. HELD too long.

— A belt CRACKS across his back. JUMP CUT mid-sound.

— The WARDEN'S FACE, sneering, lips spitting venom:

"Your dad's dead. Your mom moved on. They say she cheated on him for years."

— The boy curled on the ground, body convulsing, face hidden, welts blazing across skin.

— FLASH — his lip split, blood glistening.

— FLASH — a boot stomps his side.

— FLASH — the child's drawing "MY DAD," crumpled, stepped on.

The SOUND is jagged: shouts, jeers, laughter — each cut restarts mid-beat, fragmented, cyclical.

Noise builds, collapses, builds again — a broken record of torment.

SON (V.O.)

The boys made sure I never forgot.
The warden too. Every day. Every
word.

FLASH — CLOSE-UP of his swollen face, eyes flickering, unblinking.

SON (V.O.)

They wanted me to break.
Maybe I did.

HOLD — the boy on the hostel floor, motionless. Eyes open.
Body slack, posed like a corpse.
Silent.

CUT TO:

4. INT. BOARDING SCHOOL - DORM ROOM - NIGHT

He lies on the floor. Body slack. Eyes open. For a breath — a corpse.

The rain outside is far away. Inside his head: the faintest ghosts —

the FAN CREAK, a BELT SNAP, his mother's muffled "He loves you..."

A twitch. Air drags back into his lungs.

He rolls, wincing; blood streaks his lip. Fingers claw the floor until the knuckles blanch. He forces himself up — trembling, not from fear, from something past it.

SON (V.O.)
(half-whisper, cracked)
You can put me down. Break me...
But you don't bury me.

The VO ceases — cut dead. From here: only raw sound.

CUT TO:

5. INT. BOARDING SCHOOL - HALLWAY - NIGHT

A maintenance blackout. Only emergency EXIT signs glow. Water leaks from ceiling seams. The WARDEN patrols with a handheld torch; the cone of light slices darkness.

From shadow behind him, the BOY steps into frame — silent, deliberate.

His hands clamp the warden's throat. The torch flies — clatters far. It spins on stone and spills light across a shallow puddle: ripples bloom, reflecting stuttering light that fills the frame like a broken mind.

SILENCE — except the WARDEN'S choking gurgle.

A CRASH as the boy SLAMS him to the floor.

The boy rises, jumps down with both knees onto the man's diaphragm — a blunt exhale. He settles on his chest and starts to punch.

One blow. Two. Three.

The overhead fluorescents START TO FLICKER to life, fighting the outage — that awful tube BUZZ. The puddle's reflected light shreds the image — the ripples become a kaleidoscope.

Each punch fuels the next. The boy's face is blank. Mechanical. Beyond rage.

SOUND: a HEARTBEAT creeps in from nowhere. Each punch pushes it louder. Louder.

ONE-FRAME INSERTS — SUBLIMINAL:

- The crayon drawing: "MY DAD."
- Father's medal, glinting.
- Mother's hand flicking his away.

Back on the hallway — fists, flesh, wet breath, heartbeat.

The WARDEN goes slack. The heartbeat keeps pounding.

The boy stops. Silence rushes in, like the world held its breath and finally lets it go.

CUT

6. EXT. BOARDING SCHOOL - SOUTH WALL - NIGHT

Hard rain. A WIDE SHOT holds: the boy perched on the top of the perimeter wall, silhouetted by intermittent lightning.

He jumps.

ON IMPACT — ALL SOUND CUTS OUT. Total mute. Time holds.

Only the sight of his body absorbing the fall.

SOUND SLAMS BACK IN with a roaring thunderclap. He staggers up and runs into darkness.

SMASH CUT TO:

7. INT. BOARDING SCHOOL - PRINCIPAL'S ROOM - DAY (FLASHBACK)

A fluorescent-lit office. Clinical. The PRINCIPAL's desk is too neat: blotter, fountain pen, a framed photo of the principal's perfect family (mother, father, two kids, sunlit smiles).

The BOY sits across from the PRINCIPAL. MOTHER and STEPFATHER flank him — formal, composed. The stepfather's cap rests on his knee. His eyes avoid the boy.

CLOSE on the CONSENT FORM – institution letterhead. A dotted line awaits a name.

PRINCIPAL
(kind, rehearsed)
Now, all you have to do is sign the consent letter stating you'll abide by the rules of the school and hostel. You won't be allowed to go home until the academic year ends. It's for structure. For your good.

Her words begin to muffle – as if spoken underwater.

SOUND (SUBJECTIVE): a CLOCK TICKS too loud. PEN SCRATCHES from another office. Tube light BUZZES with a hitch. Distant rain taps the window.

The boy looks to his mother. He reaches for her hand.

She flicks his hand away – small, irritated.

FREEZE-FRAME – one beat on the gesture. A low, sub-bass THUD.

UNFREEZE.

ANGLE – THE STEPFATHER gently nudges a PEN toward the boy. Polite. Steady. The uniform's fabric creaks. He means well. It makes it worse.

PRINCIPAL (O.S.)
(muffled, continuing)
And we'll help you build discipline, routine... a strong foundation...

INSERT – The principal's FAMILY PHOTO. Smiles behind glass. Perfect. Untouchable.

BACK TO – The form. The boy's hand hovers. A drop of blood from his split knuckle falls onto the paper – a small, red comet. He presses his thumb to it without thinking. A smudged print stains the page.

The BUZZ of the tube light falters – strobes the room for a beat – then steadies.

The principal slides the form closer with two fingers, patient.

PRINCIPAL
(clear, back in reality)
Right here.

The mother adjusts her sari cuff. Doesn't look at him. The stepfather keeps his voice in his throat, eyes soft, still.

The boy stares at the line. The clock ticks. Loud. Too loud.

SMASH CUT TO:

8. EXT. EMPTY ROAD OUTSIDE BOARDING SCHOOL - NIGHT

The rain is relentless — sheets, hammering the asphalt.

CAMERA TRACKS alongside him as he runs. Low angle, shoulder height, pushing through water, every stride heavy but desperate.

Streetlights streak through the rainfall like smeared halos.

The camera cranes slightly ahead, then retreats — always pulling him forward, like fate dragging him through the storm.

SOUND: his breath. The slap of wet shoes on concrete. The rain swallowing everything else.

A car passes in the distance, headlights flaring white across the frame — briefly drowning him, then gone.

He keeps running. Faster. Rain mixing with tears, indistinguishable.

A WIDE CRANE SHOT pulls up and away as he becomes small against the dark road, swallowed by storm and distance.

CUT TO:

CLOSE-UP TRACKING SHOT #1 — TORSO & FACE

The camera glides backward, centered on his chest and face. His shirt clings, soaked. His mouth opens, dragging breath. The rain stings, but his momentum doesn't falter.

CLOSE-UP TRACKING SHOT #2 — FACE

Now tighter. His jaw clenched. Drops bead and race across his skin. The world behind him blurs to streaks. His pupils glint with defiance.

CLOSE-UP TRACKING SHOT #3 — EYES

Extreme close. His eyes lock forward — raw, alive, unbroken. He surges closer, closer, until—

CUT TO BLACK:

A SPLIT SECOND OF SILENCE.

Then — MUSIC SLAMS IN:

"Freedom" — Beyoncé & Kendrick Lamar.

At 0:06 BEAT DROP —

ON-SCREEN TITLE:

"Written and Directed by Abhinavan Malladi"

The track continues while the credits roll over storm-black.